NG5001
Academic Communication for Graduate Researchers

Key points from Week 4's tutorial discussions

Overview

- Continuing the tradition of the interdisciplinary Enlightenment era salons, we:
  - ✓Compared abstracts from contrasting disciplines in terms of stylistic choices, expression of authorial voice, objectivity for rigour, and subjectivity for engagement
  - ✓Came to an understanding that no writing is neutral and that every work comes from a particular position
  - ✓Discussed challenges when writing for cross-disciplinary contexts
  - ✓Explored inclusive strategies for cross-disciplinary contexts such as those relating to technical language & jargon
- These are considerations for the writing of the abstract for Assignment 1

Writing is interpersonal; it is a dialogue between the writer and the (imagined) audience.

- Not simply a presentation of ideas but an **engagement** between the writer and the readers
- Writer engages the readers by **guiding** them through the ideas and arguments using *interactive resources*
- Readers in turn engage with the text by **interpreting** and **evaluating** these ideas and arguments facilitated by the *interactional resources*

Table 1
A model of metadiscourse in academic texts

Category	Function	Examples
Interactive resources	Help to guide reader through the text	
Transitions	Express semantic relation between main clauses	In addition/but/thus/and
Frame markers	Refer to discourse acts, sequences, or text stages	Finally/to conclude/my purpose is to
Endophoric markers	Refer to information in other parts of the text	Noted above/see Fig./in Section 2
Evidentials	Refer to source of information from other texts	According to X/(Y, 1990)/Z states
Code glosses	Help readers grasp meanings of ideational material	Namely/e.g./such as/in other words
Interactional resources	Involve the reader in the argument	
Hedges	Withhold writer's full commitment to proposition	Might/perhaps/possible/about
Boosters	Emphasise force or writer's certainty in proposition	In fact definitely/it is clear that
Attitude markers	Express writer's attitude proposition	Unfortunately/I to agree/surprisingly
Engagement markers	Explicitly refer to or build relationship with reader	Consider/note that/you can see that
Self-mentions	Explicit reference to author(s)	I/we/my/our

An Interpersonal Model of Metadiscourse (Hyland, 2004)

On writing for cross-disciplinary audience

- The authorial voice reflects the writer's personality; in academic writing, the authorial voice should embody:
  - ✓ Persuasiveness: a confident, well-reasoned voice can persuade readers more effectively
  - ✓ Credibility: a consistent authorial voice helps establish trust and authority
  - ✓ Clarity of thought: it helps readers follow writer's logic and understand their position
- Authorial voice is inherent in **all** forms of writing, reflecting their distinctive tone, style and perspective
  - ✓ In academic writing, the strength of the authorial voice varies according disciplinary *preferences* (do note that these are NOT rules for academic writing)
  - ✓ A stronger authorial voice increases reader engagement, hence is preferable in cross-disciplinary writing
- Thus, the writer should make deliberate choices in the language and metadiscourse to project the intended voice

Key points from Unit 2.2 Task 4

- The text demonstrates that voice can be authoritative and yet still accessible without ‘dumbing down’ the language;
  - jargon is used selectively to address the specialist audience to maintain rigour and professionalism but it is not excessive to alienate non-specialist readers
  - rigour and professionalism are further reinforced through the use of evidentials
- The voice conveys assertiveness and a sense of urgency; its persuasiveness makes the text engaging

Key Points from Task 5

- If needed, use GenAI responsibly and in a reflective manner
- It may be helpful for grammar checks but do check for the appropriateness of the sentence structure
- Evaluate the output for accuracy of facts
- Evaluate the output for the intended voice; GenAI may not capture the nuances the way we do
- *If used, include **all** prompts, output and how the output is used in the assignment in a table as an appendix at the end of the paper (NUS policy on use of GenAI)

Key points from Task 6

- The abstract works for the cross-disciplinary context – it has a clear macrostructure, i.e., it follows the hourglass structure of abstracts for STEM disciplines
- The topic is clear from the start with the niche established through the literature review
- There is a sufficiently broad context for cross-disciplinary audiences; reader's prior knowledge is not assumed, and processes are explained
- However, could this abstract be improved? For instance:
    1. Could the results be more closely linked to the second part of the research objective "…a more comprehensive understanding of their clinical reliability in eye care" and conclusion?
    2. How appropriate is the phrase "naïve patients" in comparison to "competency" of the LLMs?
- Revise your abstract with a critical lens

Key points from Task 8

- While not always easy, cross-disciplinary reader understanding can be achieved using inclusive practices such as, but not limited to:
  - ✓ using non-technical language
  - ✓ avoiding or explaining jargon
  - ✓ using analogies and metaphors to explain abstract/ complex ideas (“tender-minded,”; “eats them whole”; “delivery mechanism”; “suffocating control mechanisms”)
  - ✓ eliciting emotional connection through metaphors
  - ✓ leveraging shared experiences and knowledge
  - ✓ foregrounding the social impact of the research
  - ✓ providing examples and relatable background
  - ✓ summarizing technical information (e.g. “as shown by elementary mathematical techniques”)
  - ✓ attributing of human characteristics, emotions and behaviours to non-human entities
- When establishing a common ground:
  - ✓ Aim for clarity not oversimplification or ‘dumbing down’
  - ✓ Adopt a strength-based perspective
  - ✓ Use appropriate inclusive strategies